

Verbal and Telephone Order Read-Back

Policy Number	POL-CMP-085	Owner / Department	Medical Staff / Nursing
Effective Date	2023-09-01	Version	2.3
Last Revised	2026-05-05	Next Review	2028-05-05
Approved By	Medical Executive Committee	Applies To	All licensed staff who receive verbal or telephone orders or critical test results

1. Purpose

This policy defines the read-back process for verbal and telephone orders and for reporting critical test results, consistent with The Joint Commission National Patient Safety Goal NPSG.02.03.01, to reduce communication errors at points of hand-off.

2. Policy

- Verbal orders are limited to situations where electronic or written entry is not feasible (for example, during a sterile procedure or a true emergency).
- Every verbal/telephone order and every critical result communicated verbally must be written down (or entered) and read back verbatim.
- The ordering or reporting individual must confirm the read-back is correct before the exchange ends.
- The receiver enters the order and the ordering provider authenticates (signs) it within the medical-staff timeframe.

3. Read-Back Procedure

1. **Write (or enter) down** the complete order or critical result as it is given.
2. **Read back** what you wrote, verbatim, including drug name, dose, route, and frequency; spell look-alike/sound-alike drug names.
3. **Receive confirmation** — the ordering or reporting person explicitly confirms “that is correct”.
4. Document the order with the time, the provider, and that read-back was performed.

IMPORTANT — A critical test result must be read back to the reporter and communicated to the responsible licensed caregiver within the timeframe in the critical-values protocol so that the patient can be treated promptly. If you cannot reach the responsible provider, escalate up the chain without delay.

4. Prohibited and Restricted Orders

- Chemotherapy and other high-alert verbal orders are prohibited except in defined emergencies.
- Do not use prohibited abbreviations from the facility “Do Not Use” list in any order.

- Texting of orders is not permitted; orders are entered through the approved order-entry system.

5. Severity & Reporting

Read-back failures and resulting events are classified on the facility-wide scale in POL-RM-013. A verbal-order or critical-result failure that reached a patient and caused serious harm or death is SEV-1 (notify the Administrator-on-Call and Risk Management within 1 hour). A failure that reached the patient without serious harm is SEV-2 (notify the manager and the provider within 4 hours). An error caught before reaching the patient is a Near Miss (report within 24 hours).

6. References

- The Joint Commission NPSG.02.03.01 (critical results of tests and diagnostic procedures; read-back).
- The Joint Commission "Do Not Use" list of abbreviations.
- Related: POL-PS-008 (Patient Identification), POL-RM-013 (severity & reporting).